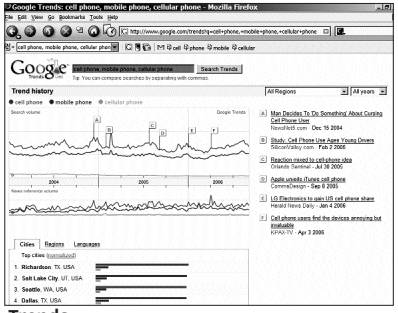
with a letter, then gives you a random headline from that date.


Trends

Beneath this, you get three tabs: what city, region, and language the term was searched for most in.

We used a controversial phrase for our test search: "gay marriage." There were several peaks, as you can see in the screenshot, and each has associated news items. As you might expect, in the Regions tab, we found that it was most searched for in the United States. In the Cities tab, naturally, cities in the states where the news appeared showed the maximum searches. You can get more detailed graphs using the Region and Date selector.

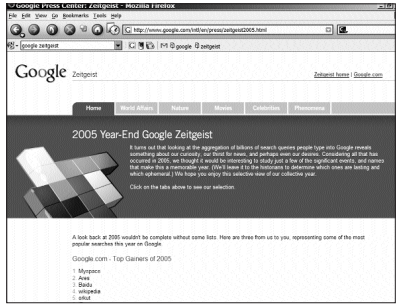
Google Trends can be fun (type in "sex," and you'll get a surprise!). When it comes to utility, it's mostly useful for those with an online business, we expect. Apart from that, you might just want to visit the page for the Trends equivalent of ego-surfing—in the sense that you might want to see how in tune you are with the world: use the search phrases you've been using and check whether you're outdated!

4.8 The Google Zeitgeist

While on the subject of Google Trends, we should touch upon the Google Zeitgeist. "Zeitgeist" isn't a made-up name; it's a German word that means "the general intellectual, moral, and cultural climate of an era," as Google puts it (rightly). (The "Z" is pronounced "ts" and the "g" is pronounced as in "gift.")

The Google Zeitgeist is a compilation of information about what people have been searching for, and what the trends in searching

have been. As a typical example, if you think about the Presidential elections, you can probably guess that at around the time Bush was elected for a second term, there would be a surge in searches for words like "Bush" and "election" and so on and so forth. You'd find such obvious things—as well as much less obvious things—recorded in the Zeitgeist.


The 2005 Zeitgeist

The main page is **www.google.com/press/zeitgeist.html**. (We wonder why Google seems to think only the press is interested in all this.) And there you'll find a characteristically grandiose, philosophical-sounding statement by Google: "What you see here is a cumulative snapshot of interesting queries people are asking—some over time, some within country domains, and some on Google.com—that perhaps reveal a bit of the human condition."

There are three "levels" of the Zeitgeist: by week, by month, and by year, though it isn't organised that way.

By Week

When you click the main link—"Gaining Search Queries: Week Ending October 30, 2006" (at the time of writing)—you'll see the top "gainers" in search for that week. The week you see will be the week that just ended. This won't be of much interest to most people, since it's a trend for only a week—and it probably reflects the state of the news anyway, which is still fresh in one's mind.

By Month

By month, a Zeitgeist has been "compiled." It takes some time for a monthly Zeitgeist to be compiled, so, for example, in October, you'll find the monthly Zeitgeist for August. This is, of course, the top